December 2026 link proposals — at a glance

All 15 proposals against today's link — the three shortlisted ones marked ★, Even Step recommended — sorted by December rules met, then avoidable fatigue warnings, then by name; a proposal that breaks a hard limit cannot be run as it stands and comes last. Every figure is worked out from the rota, by the Marylebone Roster app's own checks and the tooling beside them. Staffing levels and Sunday cover confirmed verbally (29 Sep 2026); the 26-line link, 5 cover weeks and a ceiling of 219 contracted days a year set on 1 Oct 2026.

Proposal · code	December rules met	Avoidable fatigue warnings§	Most days in a row§	Full weekends off	Shortest fixed-duty rest	Shift times	Days a year*	Heaviest week, Mon–Sat	Weeks on one turn	Weeks mixing earlies and lates	Week-to-week change of start	Finishes 23:00+ a year†
Today's link 20 weeks	4 of 9	4 up to 5§	7 up to 9§	4 in 20 about 10 a year · 7 weeks apart at most	12h 30m	18	219.0	43h 50m	7 of 16 blocks 2 (up to 3)	7	4h 00m	39
Both Ways BW-26-T3	**9 of 9**	**0** up to 1§	5 up to 7§	7 in 26 about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most	14h 20m	14 (4 new)	218.6	40h 55m	16 of 21 blocks 5 (up to 7)	0	1h 40m	42
Closing Time CT-26-T2	**9 of 9**	**0** up to 1§	5 up to 7§	7 in 26 about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most	14h 35m	13 (5 new)	218.6	41h 30m	17 of 21 blocks 5 (up to 7)	0	1h 10m	42
Even Keel EK-26-H1	**9 of 9**	**0** up to 1§	5 up to 7§	7 in 26 about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most	14h 35m	15 (7 new)	218.6	41h 30m	18 of 21 blocks 5 (up to 12)	1	1h 16m	44
★ shortlisted · recommended **Even Step** ES-26-T5	**9 of 9**	**0** up to 1§	5 up to 7§	7 in 26 about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most	14h 35m	13 (5 new)	218.6	41h 30m	18 of 21 blocks 5 (up to 7)	0	1h 31m	42
Fine Tune FT-26-H1	**9 of 9**	**0** up to 1§	5 up to 7§	7 in 26 about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most	14h 35m	15 (7 new)	218.6	41h 30m	16 of 21 blocks 5 (up to 12)	1	1h 09m	44
Home Grown HG-26-T1	**9 of 9**	**0** up to 1§	5 up to 7§	7 in 26 about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most	14h 35m	12 (2 new)	218.6	42h 30m	16 of 21 blocks 5 (up to 7)	0	1h 25m	42
★ shortlisted **In Step** IS-26-T4	**9 of 9**	**0** up to 1§	5 up to 7§	7 in 26 about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most	14h 35m	15 (6 new)	218.6	41h 05m	18 of 21 blocks 5 (up to 7)	0	1h 13m	42
Long Break LB-26-F1	**9 of 9**	**0** up to 1§	6 up to 7§	7 in 26 about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most	14h 20m	15 (6 new)	218.6	42h 00m	16 of 21 blocks 5 (up to 9)	0	1h 44m	42
Second Edition SE-26-F1	**9 of 9**	**0** up to 1§	6 up to 7§	7 in 26 about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most	14h 20m	15 (6 new)	218.6	42h 00m	18 of 21 blocks 5 (up to 7)	0	1h 01m	42
Second Gear SG-26-H1	**9 of 9**	**0** up to 1§	5 up to 7§	7 in 26 about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most	14h 35m	15 (7 new)	218.6	41h 30m	16 of 21 blocks 5 (up to 12)	2	1h 25m	44
Second Look SL-26-G3	**9 of 9**	**0**	6	7 in 26 about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most	14h 20m	14 (6 new)	218.6	43h 40m	15 of 21 blocks 4 (up to 6)	1	1h 30m	42
Second Nature SN-26-F2	**9 of 9**	**0** up to 1§	6 up to 7§	7 in 26 about 14 a year · 10 weeks apart at most	14h 20m	15 (6 new)	218.6	43h 40m	15 of 21 blocks 4 (up to 6)	2	1h 28m	42
Second Sight SS-26-F1	**9 of 9**	**0** up to 1§	6 up to 7§	7 in 26 about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most	14h 20m	15 (6 new)	218.6	42h 00m	16 of 21 blocks 4 (up to 6)	0	1h 55m	42
Second Wind SW-26-F1	**9 of 9**	**0** up to 1§	6 up to 7§	7 in 26 about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most	14h 20m	15 (6 new)	218.6	42h 30m	16 of 21 blocks 4 (up to 6)	4	2h 01m	42
★ shortlisted **Short Run** SR-26-F1	**9 of 9**	**0** up to 1§	5 up to 7§	7 in 26 about 14 a year · 5 weeks apart at most	14h 20m	15 (6 new)	218.6	42h 30m	18 of 21 blocks 5 (up to 7)	0	1h 13m	42

* Monday to Saturday, with a cover week counted as 4 days (Sundays are overtime and left out). † Each person, on average across the whole link, Sundays included; cover-week duties are not known yet and are left out. "Shift times" counts different start–finish times; "new" means nobody works that time today. "Weeks on one turn" means one shift time Monday to Friday, all earlies or all lates; beneath it, the longest block of weeks in a row on one kind, "up to" if the cover weeks beside it go the same way. The week-to-week change is the average move of the start time from one week to the next. § On the duties the rota fixes, the cover weeks left out for the proposal and today alike; "up to" is the worst place a cover week's four duties could fall, its Sunday worked as overtime. Avoidable fatigue warnings come from the ORR's good-practice list plus rail-industry checks, leaving out the two that come with every weekly link — reported, never pass or fail. Full detail for each proposal is in its own eight-page sheet; the rules themselves are in links-26-rules.pdf.